



THE WHITESTONE FOUNDATION

What is the Whitestone Foundation? “Knowledge Futures for the 21st Century”

A Prospectus



The global economy in the 21st century is what the celebrated business management theorist Peter Drucker dubbed a “knowledge economy”. What that means, simply stated, is that the creation, maintenance, and generation of wealth itself depends on the production and shaping of knowledge. But as we move into the second quarter of the new millennium the knowledge economy itself is experiencing upheavals and disruptions that threaten to destabilize and unmoor it.

The institutional engines of knowledge production themselves are faltering. Despite double-digit growth in spending on public schools over the last decade, national test scores are in steady decline, especially in science and math. While the costs of higher education continue to balloon, fewer students are going to college. A recent survey by a prominent national polling agency found that almost two thirds of Americans today believe a college education is not worth the money.

Meanwhile, one quarter of all private institutions of higher learning, it is predicted, will close within the next five years. And the transformation of knowledge itself by AI is forcing our pundits and

policy makers to radically reconceive the very architecture of the global knowledge economy as a whole. *The thought leadership of the Whitestone Foundation is prepared for this moment.*

For twenty-five years we at Whitestone have published, convened, and issued challenges across many academic fields and professions in order to call attention to emerging dynamics of a world in which the old frameworks and assumptions no longer hold. We stride into our next quarter-century with a keener focus, a broader ambition, and a resounding reply to the question of what it means to navigate a planetary space roiled by globalization gone wild and the revolution in intelligence that are raising up “knowledge futures” that we can only begin to imagine?

OUR CALLING

The knowledge economy is trembling at its very foundations. What we have called learning and education for two centuries was largely about certification, the gatekeeping of approved information, and the transmission of technical skills. That model is now obsolete.

There are no longer any “gates” for the “gatekeepers” to keep. The credentialing that higher education has systemically — and hitherto expensively — provided no longer requires the massive corporate and government bureaucracy that has overloaded millions of recent and not-so-recent college graduates with student loan debt. Digital technology has made the “stock” of basic knowledge an infinitely cheap commodity. What remains — what cannot be automated or outsourced— are strategies by which knowledge can be deployed creatively and impactfully. In other words, what remains is the task of thinking.

One of our own thought leaders, Gary Bedford, has coined the expression “wild globalization” to name the set of conditions that not only generated the present “crisis,” but which define the full 300,000-year history of *Homo sapien* presence on Earth. Wild globalization is understood as the persistent human “critical condition” which emerges — rather than merely evolves from the more or less *free and unrestrained (“wild”) human creative-destructive value response* to the world. This critical condition only “works” when it is complemented by “critical thinking,” or “wisdom.” Hence, the human condition, its magnificent achievements, and horrific downfalls, as well as its uneven and even asymmetrical distributions, are primarily attributable to the presence or absence and progression of *knowledge* and particularly “*useful knowledge*.” As this condition has mushroomed exponentially during the recent Enlightenment-Industrial-Technological-Information and now AI revolutions, the condition has only grown wilder. Rather than “civilized,” civilization must be re-envisioned as an increasingly “wild” phenomenon.

We seek to imagine wild and unimagined futures — *knowledge futures* that remain realistic and optimistic at the same time.

WHO WE ARE

What is the Whitestone Foundation? It is not a school, a consultancy, or a think tank in the conventional sense. We are a *knowledge community* — a gathering place where thoughtful people collaborate in charting new and compelling “thinkscapes” which we can all inhabit in the 21st century.

Founded in 1999 on the cusp of the new millennium as a Colorado-registered 501© 3 non-profit corporation by a pair of philosophy professors and academic visionaries (Carl Raschke, University of Denver and Charles Winquist, holder of the Watson Chair at Syracuse University), we have been intellectual pioneers in the advancement of the arts and letters in the digital age.

Although we did not invent electronic publishing, we started up electronic journals — *Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory* (philosophy of religion), *The New Polis* (political thought) , and *Esthesis* (Visual Arts) — long before online scholarly publishing became a “thing”. We also set the pace for international online video conferences and podcasting almost 20 years ago with our “Critical Conversations”, and today our online conclaves on everything from the environment to the future of democracy to the crisis of educational systems routinely garner international participation and attention. Right after the trauma of 9/11 we pulled together academics, public intellectuals, and Washington consultants together in Aspen, Colorado and published a series of timely thought pieces on the crisis confronting us at the very onset of this century. Starting in September we will be hosting a major international conference on the topic of “cognitive warfare”, touching on both political science and security studies.

Today as the AI revolution gathers full steam and transforms societies and economies, we remain at the forefront of deliberating and debating what it all means. Our symposium and “think lab” on “Critical Thinking in the Age of AI” is slated to launch in the fall of 2026. Our prospectus for the symposium states that it “will bring together philosophers of mind and technology, cognitive scientists, pedagogical theorists, and practitioners across post-secondary sectors to address a single integrating question — what does critical thinking require, and how must it be taught, when artificial intelligence mediates so much of cognition and knowledge generation?”

We are building an integrated five-part organization whose components reinforce each other at each level and whose value lies in their assembly, not in any one segment alone. We are poised to produce a regular stream of white papers and critical research summaries on how knowledge production is undergoing unprecedented transformation in the age of artificial intelligence.

KNOWLEDGE FUTURES

Our single unifying approach is the development of what we call “knowledge futures” — a systematic inquiry into what the condition of knowledge will be across the various domains and disciplines that shape intellectual life — civic and political order, community formation and resilience, economic and ecological challenges, and new prospects for international order.

As architects of knowledge futures, we bring together the most significant representatives and resources of the liberal arts — philosophy, history, theology, political theory, cultural analysis — and deploy them toward mapping bold new strategic paths forward in a wild, unpredictable world. “Civic co-intelligence” — thinking together about “existentially” compelling and socially consequential questions with intellectual rigor and collegial co-working — is how we move forward together in practice.

KNOWLEDGE AND WEALTH

Knowledge has always been the principal driver of wealth formation — not capital alone, not industrial policy, not the vicissitudes of markets. Every advancement in human well-being has derived from the optimized application of collective knowledge across time and space. It has relied on human ingenuity in bridling the forces of nature and history that disrupt and impede human progress. As civilization globalizes while becoming more wild and chaotic, the communities that will thrive are those that know the entire score and possess the intellectual wherewithal to respond appropriately. They will become the custodians of the emerging global *knowledge commons*.

This is how and why legacy-based philanthropy becomes so important for the maintenance of the knowledge commons and the enhancement of future knowledge trajectories. The most urgent question for those who have amassed or inherited productive resources is not how to preserve them in the narrow sense, but how to steer them toward goals and initiatives that upgrade our knowledge futures. The Whitestone Foundation serves to forge the very architecture for this kind of strategic giving. Contributing to Whitestone is an impactful and long-term investment in the growth of the knowledge commons that supports human flourishing in the first place.

The Whitestone Academy enables families, community groups, couples, and individuals to address these questions as public educational programming:

- How knowledge gels and transmits across generations
- What it means to nurture organizations and institutions that outlast their founders
- How philanthropy directed at knowledge infrastructure transforms the communities it enters.

These are the questions of civic intelligence. They are the questions Whitestone is designed to address, and to help communities act upon.